



## THE SILK ROAD

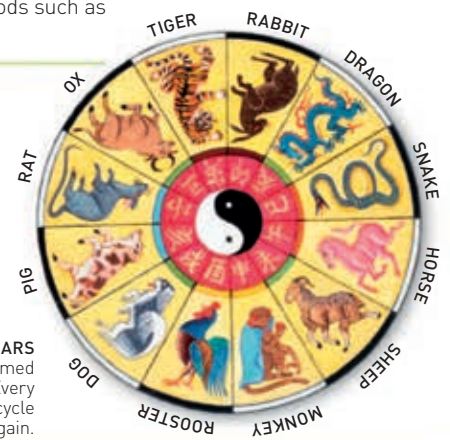
The Silk Road was a route that ran from China across Asia towards Europe. It was protected by the Chinese, so that traders from all over the world could use it safely. Chinese merchants became very rich by exporting goods such as silk, tea, porcelain, and spices.

KEY

— Silk Road

## TAICHU CALENDAR

The traditional Chinese calendar dates back thousands of years. It was first officially recorded in 104 BCE, during the rule of Han Wudi.



**ANIMAL YEARS**  
Each year is named after an animal. Every 12 years, the cycle starts over again.



## MYTHS AND LEGENDS

Chinese mythology was a rich mix of traditional folk tales, legends based on real people, and stories adapted from Buddhist and Daoist teaching.



**THREE SOVEREIGNS**  
According to legend, the first rulers of China.

**SUN WUKONG**  
Monkey king with superpowers.

**EIGHT IMMORTALS**  
Able to bestow life and destroy evil.

## ART AND CRAFTS

The exquisite creations of Chinese artisans were always in demand, both at home and abroad. Craftspeople enjoyed high status in society, above the merchants who sold their work.



## THE THREE WAYS

Imperial China was generally tolerant of different religions. People were free to choose which of the three popular belief systems they wished to follow.



**CONFUCIANISM**  
Followed the rules of Chinese thinker Confucius.

**BUDDHISM**  
A philosophy begun by Buddha, a north Indian prince.

**DAOISM**  
Daoists followed legendary Chinese philosopher Lao Zi.

## DRESSING UP

Rich people wore splendid robes, made of the finest silk. Peasants wore loose clothes made of hemp, a rough, scratchy fabric made from plant fibres.